Boy Lost and Wendy

By Nakita Gill

INTRODUCTION

Based on J.M. Barrie's play and novel of the same name, Disney's animated musical follows a girl and her brothers who are swept into the magical world of Neverland by a boy named Peter Pan.

And, of course, you've heard of Captain Hook, Pan's dreaded enemy. Ferocious and terrible, he terrorizes Peter and his merry band of boys. But exactly how did Captain Hook become Peter's greatest enemy? And whatever became of Wendy Darling? Nakita Gill in her short prose selections Boy Lost and Wendy provides some possible answers.

BOY LOST

(Pg 20-24) Picture a sunset in a small port town by the sea. Two teenaged boys sitting on the docks watching the ships as they fly across the water. One reaches out and takes the other's hand. In this brush of skin for skin, a thousand unspoken promises erupt between them, and both are determined to keep them. This is what youth is. The sheer belief that you will be able to keep every promise

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you made to someone else. That you will be able to love someone into a forever when you do not even understand what forever means.

An evening spent in the headiness of love, they go back to their respective homes. One boy helps his mother with cooking and cleaning and looking after his little sister. His father is a good man, a sailor who brings home with him meagre wages, but a heart full of love and a quicksilver tongue that tells stories of faraway lands to enthral them all. But this boy, despite his blessings, is not happy. He may have been blessed with a loving family, but that faraway look is made of unrest and wanderlust, something about him says fae, changeling, wearing the skin of a boy who was always destined to fly, to leave.

The other boy returns home to a father who drinks and a mother who works so hard that she is never there. He is the unwanted creature in this home, a beating waiting for him at every corner. His father's temper is a beast so powerful that a boy made of paper bones barely held together cannot fight him. He hides in his room. He lives for a boy at sunset, hope made into a human being.

Now picture this. This boy of paper bones alone at the

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docks the next sunset. And this boy alone on the docks again on a rainy day. And this boy alone on the docks every day after, waiting for someone who promised him forevers he never

intended to keep. This boy becoming a man, a heart wounded so young in youth that it never quite healed right. Imagine him becoming a sailor, searching land after land for a boy he once loved, thinking he was hurt, or stolen, just needing to know what happened to him.

Now see him finally finding out that the boy he loved in his boyhood ran away to a magical land where he never grew up. That without a second glance, he just forgot every promise of forever. Imagine his rage, that ancient pain turning to a terrible anger and escaping from the forgotten attic of his mangled heart. Think of what happens when immense love turns into immense hate. An anger so intense it cannot be controlled. What he would give up to avenge the boy he once was, paper-boned, standing on the docks, broken without a single person to love him, simply all alone. A hand is a small price to pay for a magical ship that will take him to Neverland, a place that lives on a star. Becoming a villain called Captain Hook is a small exchange

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to show Peter Pan that you cannot throw away love and think you will get away unscarred.

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WENDY

[And what ever happened to Wendy?] No one talks about what happened to Wendy Darling after they returned from Neverland. No one speaks of Wendy Darling anymore. The truth is, whilst her parents were able to convince her brothers that Neverland never happened, that all children must grow up, that it was all just a dream, Wendy knew better and she vehemently believed.

She believed when her friends made fun of her in boarding school. She wished for the fairies to save her when she went to the headteacher's office and her parents were forced to remove her. She even spoke to Peter after that when she was homeschooled by her governess. As she grew older, the visions of Neverland never quite ceased and she painted and drew pictures showing her wonderful adventures with Peter and the Lost Boys. She didn't realise her parents were slowly growing concerned and wrung their hands about how she would ever find a man to marry,

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if she still believed in all this nonsense.

Things came to a head when Wendy refused to marry. Soon they grew so worried that they had Wendy placed in an asylum, claiming her hallucinations were so terrible that they needed tending. You would think the story would end there, but Wendy had a powerful faith in herself and in the strength of her own mind and memory.

So from the asylum she began to write stories and paint pictures of Neverland for children, impressing every doctor, soothing the patients to the point that her doctor, a kind-hearted man, began to send her work to publishers. Wendy, slowly but surely, became so adamant and so polite to her doctors that they began to question their own sanity, because she remained so unfalteringly faithful to her story. However, if she had no means of supporting herself, she would never be able to leave

this asylum, and knowing this was going to be her fate, Wendy once again wished upon the fairies.

They had never paid her any mind before, but her fervour made them pay attention. Because they guided her to send her writings and paintings to a publisher who

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absolutely loved what she was doing. They offered her enough money to leave the asylum, which she could when she turned 21, and support herself; something almost unheard of in their circle of society.

Wendy died a happy old maid, with a dozen books she had written, a stunning library, and a host of friends and nephews and nieces that absolutely loved and thought the world of her.

But this is the reason why no one talks of Wendy Darling anymore. Because the most successful children's books of her time, the adventures in Neverland, were never published under the name of Wendy Darling, but simply under 'Wendy'.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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